

**Harry Downes Field Playground
Design Review Committee Meeting
Town Hall, 1st Floor, Room 103
Monday, June 20, 2017, 7:00 p.m.**

Committee Members Present: John Bain, Daniel Lyons, Antonia Bellalta and Wendy Sheridan

Staff Present: Jessica Zarni, Administrative Assistant, Jessie Waisnor, Landscape Designer, Erin Gallentine, Parks and Open Space Director, Alex Cassie, Park Ranger

Guests Present: see attached

Welcome/Call Meeting to Order

J. Bain opened the meeting. He stated it is going to be an exciting project.

E. Gallentine introduced herself. She stated she is so excited to kick off the process. E. Gallentine introduced the four Park and Recreation Commissioners, Jessie Waisnor, Jessica Zarni, Administrative Assistant, and Alex Cassie, Park Ranger.

E. Gallentine will be talking about the goals, process and funding.

J. Waisnor will be doing an existing conditions and site analysis, and then there will be an open discussion.

E. Gallentine went through the goals and priorities of the project.

E. Gallentine described the makeup of the design review process. The Design review Committee will come to a final design concept and then it will go before the full Park and Recreation Commission for a vote.

E. Gallentine discussed the project budget and timeline.

J. Waisnor introduced herself.

J. Waisnor gave a context of the park neighborhood with an aerial view.

J. Waisnor listed the park entrances. There are 7 entrances in total.

E. Gallentine described the perimeter conditions/edges.

The site fencing was discussed.

The current play equipment was shown and described.

The lawns and planting were discussed. She stated that there are a lot of great trees in the park.

J. Waisnor discussed the athletic fields. There are two types of one synthetic turf the other natural turf field .

The site furniture was discussed.

J. Bain opened the meeting up to discussion.

Paula Narenhlumcihs addressed the Commission members. She asked if you have a plan in mind or is this for us to talk. E. Gallentine stated that we have priorities that were listed and really the intent for the rest of conversation is to just get input on what you would like to see as part of the renovation. P. Narenhlumchis would like to hear input on the chain link fence. There are always pieces of the fence hanging out, it would be nice to see other options that would be able to withstand the plows and the amount of use it has. She stated it is a hazard, it's dangerous with the metal and is always sticking out.

Carol Nelson addressed the Commission members. She was on the last design review committee for Harry Downes in 2005. She stated that it has increased usage which is fine for the most part, however parking is an issue and that was a big concern when the committee met initially back in 2005. She stated there is no patrolling of the street; she stated that it continues to be a problem for people/neighbors. She is interested in the playground; she has grandchildren who spend time there. She is wondering if there are ideas for having playground equipment for all ages. E. Gallentine stated that it's a small playground and she thinks that maybe we are looking at play for 2-5 year olds and something that would be appealing to kids up to 8. C. Nelson thinks its small and it is a really a toddler playground. It could use some upgrade but it more or less it is a toddler delegated playground. She thinks a lot of people came here tonight with thoughts that your intentions were to put in bleachers, lights and concessions stand. E. Gallentine stated that is not intent nor is there budget for that.

Sandy McLeary addressed the Commission members. She wanted to support what was said about the park so far regarding parking, it is a serious problem and it's really hard to have to go to the park and try to find out who owns the car and who is blocking a driveway. She stated that it will get worse with more users. She likes the way the park is now. She is concerned about having more people and activity is going to be really noisy. She has a feeling if the noise gets worse her family can't enjoy their front porch.

Marjorie Pasher addressed the Commission members. She asked if there is any intention to remove any trees. J. Waisnor stated that we will perform a site analysis to look at the health of the trees, but at this point there are no intentions on removing trees. She wondered if there are access points you are looking to add and thinking about maybe removing trees. E. Gallentine stated that we need to do assessment of all the grading and this will be an

opportunity to do a stem by stem inspection of the trees and do both structural and health pruning. E. Gallentine stated that we have no intention of taking out healthy trees that service the park well. She wants to understand what exactly our intention is. E. Gallentine stated that we do not have any intentions other than priorities that she laid out beforehand, but what she is hearing is that we all care about character of the park and maintaining the trees.

Mike Glover addressed the Commission members. He wanted to make sure we are doing outreach to the folks live in High Street Park, making sure we are getting their input and talking to Brookline Housing Authority about what they think.

Alan Cohen addressed the Commission members. He was wondering if there is a reason why the long jump was not included in the artificial turf area and he is wondering why the fence line is there. E. Gallentine agrees and stated that is something that is going to be looked at this time around. She stated that the fence came later. He stated that with respect to the parking it's not a design change per say but maybe an opportunity to have some communication with the coaches and teams.

Roe Daves addressed the Commission members. He stated that the park is something sometimes closed of weather conditions, other than that he is at the park every day. It has a strong impact of the quality of life for himself and his dog. He stated that there are times certain groups meet and has bubbled over into group gatherings outside of the park. He knows that dogs and sandpits are incompatible, but he thinks the people who use it the most aside from the students and the walkers are the dog users. He stated it is a strong program and a strong component of his life and many others. He wants to make sure that it continues to be a dog shared park.

Steve O'Neill addressed the Commission members. He thinks the park has really been tremendous with all the changes that have been made at the last design review process. The artificial turf has turned out to be a great thing. The multi-use nature of the park has been terrific and all the sociability and all the other aspects that go along with it. The fence when it was added in middle was a great addition and it was very successful that the dog walkers are not interfering with sports. The natural turf field has very poor drainage and it is pretty uneven. He thinks the field gets a lot of use in the fall and the left out football equipment has torn up the field and has become a problem. He stated that the parking issues are something that the neighborhood continues to struggle with. He thinks one of the highlights of this park is that it is fenced in completely.

A resident addressed the Commission members. She would like to put in a word for the dog park and she hope that it stays fenced in.

Lisa LaFrance addressed the Commission members. She loves the enclosed dog park, but she also has a child and she doesn't think we should be referring to the grass side as a dog park. She thinks we should have community bulletin billboards there with the rules of the Green Dog Program. She thinks that fence being moved is essential, that way all the track and field is on the artificial turf field side. She stated that the entrances for dog park aspect

should be more in the middle. She would like to make sure there is proper placement of gates for the water fountain. She would like to see more water fountains. She doesn't want to see tax dollars wasted for trees and shrubs that will be peed on by the dogs.

Charlie Govau addressed the Commission members. He likes the Green Dog Program, he goes there every day. He wanted to talk about the entrances to the park and if it possible to have double gates. The double gates would make it a lot safer for dogs entering the parks. The double gates make people realize they should shut the gates. He thinks if you put signs on all the gates of the fenced in green dog area it would help a lot.

A resident discussed the sections of the fence that are in poor condition from the DPW throwing snow over the fence. She thinks it should be made much more presentable. E. Gallentine stated that sections of the fence are on the contractors list.

A resident asked about the fences being moving in 2-3 feet so the plows would not hit it.

Robert Simpson addressed the Commission members. He has observed the issue with the fence live, it's the poles and the distance from the fence. He asked that once the fence is compromised how long should we expect it to be repaired. He has a toddler and it's a problem. E. Gallentine stated that the trade's crew has tried to come address the worst, but now it's a tough market with fence contractors. She stated that we have had our list of work over 4 months. The contractors are in high demand. It is a problem but we are going right up chain to president of the companies. It is a continual contract the town has for repair.

Adam Williams addressed the Commission members. He has noticed that litter that has been a problem up there. The other thing that struck him was the trash compactor on Jamaica road that people are putting dog poop in trash compactor and in the summer time there is a distinct aroma. He doesn't know methods of handling the dog feces from the regular trash might be something you can look into.

Anthony Narrow addressed the Commission members. He wanted to echo a couple of points; the outreach to the Housing Authority should be a top priority to make sure all the residents feel included in the process, the playground is small but it is heavily used and the one thing it lacks is a water component, he would like to see that space maximized and believes that the kids in the neighborhood deserves a water feature. He knows people love the green dog program. He would like to see a water fountain at the track. He wonders if the softball/ green dog space is being maximized and wonders how we can better use it. He wonders if the big mound can be leveled off.

J. Waisnor stated that we leave sand up to neighbors about keeping or getting rid of sand.

Meizi Huong addressed the Commission members. She wanted to see if the sand box could be made smaller and she would like to see more swings. She wonders if you could change the direction of the swings so you could have extra two seats. She thinks a water feature would be great. She would like to see the playground offer equipment for up children up to 12 years old, she believes that the teenagers need a place to go.

E. Gallentine stated that it is an industry standard that play structures are designed for 2-5 and then 5-12 year olds. She stated that there is a lot to look at to maximize playground space see what can fit and we might need to look at tradeoffs. She stated that we can come back with a whole suit of play options for everyone to look at.

Sarah O'Neill addressed the Commission members. She wanted to weigh in on some of things that have been brought up. She thinks there needs to be more water fountains and she would like to see ones that accommodate dogs. She thinks in terms of playground there is unused park space between the blue field and playground; she doesn't know why that can't be considered for playground things. She thinks the fence should be moved. She thinks that in terms of the plowing, she hugely appreciates they remove all the snow but she thinks it's worse on Highland than Jamaica. She wants to reinforce the idea that maybe setting that fence back would help.

Phyllis O'Leary addressed the Commission members. She stated for the longest time she felt strongly there should be some water park over in the tot area. She thinks it's important to have some water feature there. She doesn't think the sand box needs to be that big. The parking problems are ongoing. She is concerned when kids come over from the high school there is not enough stands. She would like to see another one or two of the smaller stands that we already have. She stated there aren't enough places for people to sit. She stated that high school kids walk from the high school, they are playing in 80 to 90 degree weather she doesn't understand why we do not have a bus that takes kids from the high school drops them off after they are finished with practice. She stated that overall other than having some changes and upgrading she is very happy with the park. The biggest complaints are the issues with the parking.

A resident addressed the Commission members. She stated that her kids love the sand pit. She discussed the sand boxes in the parks. She likes sand but she isn't sure how to make it cleaner. She likes the idea of water features. She like would to see some better access points. She stated the bathrooms are so far away. She discussed water fountains. E. Gallentine discussed the upgraded water fountains that they are rolling out in newly renovated parks.

A resident stated that about a year ago there was talk about building a wall in the back end of the park and she wonders if it's still on the table. The Park and Recreation Commission voted that down.

A resident stated that seating overall is in interesting concept.

A resident suggested having Robinson house older kids play equipment and Harry Downes could house the toddler play equipment. She stated that there is no water fountain in the green area, she thinks it would be great to have one in the track area.

A resident wanted to point out that one of the most popular features at Clark Park is the group of stones.

A resident asked the Commission members if it possible to have a resident from the Public Housing on the DRC. J. Bain stated that they have an opportunity to write in and be on the design Review. She thinks even if something like we got was given to all of the residents and then they can decide for themselves to be involved.

Chris Blessen addressed the commission members. He is thinking that there is maybe an opportunity for the edge of the entire park to provide a learning nature educational path that goes along that edge. He stated you could make it so that it there are creative, thoughtful stations or spots so you can learn something about nature. It could create an interesting activity along the whole park and coordinates everything back together. This could create a learning component.

Rob Daves addressed the Commission members. The picnic table share important features of who use it. He stated that in the past they were taken by the athletics, moved and since then they have been chained down. He thinks maybe we could find some stationary picnic tables. He thinks the signage on the outside of the park is extremely ineffective. He would like to see a boot scraper there for himself.

Steve O'Neil addressed the Commission members. He wanted to follow up on signage. He thinks it is the visual signage that makes a difference. He thinks it is worth looking at signage and making things pictured and less verbiage would be helpful.

A resident would like to see tow zone signage instead of no parking.

Anthony Narrow addressed the Commission members. There have been points made that are outside the jurisdiction of the Commission and thinks that the Commission should make recommendations to the Transportation Board and DPW. He thinks coming from the Park and Recreation commission it is something different. J. Bain stated that the Commission does do that upon request.

A resident stated that she would like to see someone for the High School/Athletics Department that can participate. She stated that there all boot camp work outs and lacrosse teams at 5:30 am, they were going through workouts and screaming at the top of their lungs. She would like someone from there invited to our meetings.

Terry Qwan addressed the Commission members. She knows it is not the Park and Recreation jurisdiction, but after DPW came in and redid all of the curbs. There are 7 two family houses and each house has a driveway, they each got a new granite curb that cuts the lengths between driveways and they are too short. The parking is hanging over both driveways because it is not the full length of a car. She suggested moving parking to the field side as an experiment.

A resident wanted reiterate that somehow the Park and Recreation and the High School Athletics Team need to be on board with trash and parking. She stated it seems unfair to the police, when these teams should be talking to these parents. J. Bain stated that

Recreation does have meetings with all these teams and coaches but the enforcement is another issue.

Nancy O'Connor stated that she thinks it's a good reminder that in Jan/Feb the Recreation Department as a meeting with all field user of all sports and go over what happened in the last 12 months and all this information is helpful to have. She stated that at the last DRC there was a lot of discussion about parking and she thinks this is just a reminder its breaking down and we need to bring it back together. The Athletics Department and the Park and Recreation Commission talk all the time, and these are good bits of information to have a as a reminder.

Marjorie Psher addressed the Commission members. She stated initially when the artificial turf went in the police were on board with coming around and being present and it seemed like there was a lot less violations. She stated that recently she has had the police say to me can you see the person's license plate. She believes that they call them. She stated that that action spreads and she is grateful when the police come. She thinks the police department needs to be engaged in the process.

Thomas Elwertowski addressed the Commission members. He stated that one of reasons why so many people agreed to support artificial turf was the promise that the field would not be permanently lined and he wants to make sure that isn't going to change.

Erin Gallentine stated that at the June Park and Recreation Commission meeting the Commission is concerned with the synthetic turf carpet has reached end of its effective life cycle. The request was made to bring forward the replacement of the synthetic turf field so could move together as one project and we will not know until the fall how that fits in the capitol improvement overall.

Alex Cassie, Park Ranger addressed the commission Members. He Has seen Donwes field through the lens of the manager of green dog program. He does think a very important distinction to be made is that Downes field is not a dog park, he is very passionate about the Green Dog Program but the corner stone it is for multi-use space. He stated that we need to make sure we have the spaces available to everyone. We do not want to exclude anyone and not refer to it as a dog park. He stated that one of the big successors the of the green dog programs is because we are not monopolizing the space and its multi-use. The community as a whole can use the multi-use spaces. He stated that we need to maintain the balance.

Robert Simpson and E. Gallentine discussed the carpet fibers on the artificial turf.

J. Bain stated that we have a good overview of concerns and ideas and they have all been recorded. He stated that next September he hopes that everyone will come back to the next meeting.

J. Bain thanked everyone for coming and adjourned the meeting.

